

SHIP AND STORES
HAVE GONE,
SO NOW WE'LL
GO HOME.

— Ernest Shackleton, 1915

His ship was crushed by Antarctic ice, 1,500 miles from help; he refused despair and led all 28 men home alive. The line is what he told the crew as the *Endurance* went under.

OPTIMISM IS TRUE MORAL COURAGE.

— Ernest Shackleton

From the same man who brought every one of his men off the ice. Optimism here isn't naivety — it's the discipline of deciding to go home when the ship is gone.

"Just have one more try —"

IT'S DEAD EASY
TO DIE.
IT'S THE KEEPING-
ON-LIVING
THAT'S HARD.

— Robert Service, **The Quitter**, 1912

These are the lines Douglas Mawson recalled while hanging at the end of his rope in an Antarctic crevasse — the words that made him climb out instead of letting go.

"You have seen how a man was made a slave —"

A SLAVE WAS MADE A MAN.

— Frederick Douglass, 1845

At roughly sixteen, enslaved and nearly broken, Douglass fought his "breaker" for two hours, was never whipped again, and became one of history's great voices. The set-up line above pays off in the hero line.

THE DAY HAD
PASSED FOREVER
WHEN I COULD BE
A SLAVE IN
FACT.

— Frederick Douglass, 1845

What Douglass wrote of the moment he decided he would not be broken. The chains stayed a while longer; the decision was already permanent.

HE WHO HAS A
WHY
TO LIVE FOR
CAN BEAR
ALMOST ANY
HOW.

— Friedrich Nietzsche

The line Viktor Frankl carried through three years in the Nazi camps and named as the core of what he learned there: the survivors weren't the strongest bodies — they were the ones with a reason.

THE LAST OF THE
HUMAN FREEDOMS
—
TO CHOOSE
ONE'S ATTITUDE
IN ANY
CIRCUMSTANCE.

— Viktor Frankl, **Man's Search for Meaning**

Frankl found that the camps could take everything — family, health, name — but not the freedom to choose his own response. That last inner freedom is what keeps a life a life.

THE BEST WAY OUT IS ALWAYS THROUGH.

— Robert Frost, *A Servant to Servants*, 1914

From Frost's 1914 collection *North of Boston*. There's no clever detour around the hard thing; the exit runs straight through the middle of it.

Audentes fortuna iuvat

FORTUNE FAVORS THE BOLD.

— Virgil, **Aeneid**

A line roughly two thousand years old, still true: the world tilts, slightly, toward the person willing to move first. The Latin sits small beneath as the pedigree.

IT DOES NOT
MATTER
HOW SLOWLY YOU
GO
AS LONG AS
YOU DO NOT
STOP.

— Confucius (traditional)

The whole doctrine of grit in one sentence. Pace is negotiable. Stopping is the only real failure. (Traditionally attributed to Confucius; see SOURCES for the attribution note.)

WE ARE WHAT WE
REPEATEDLY DO.
EXCELLENCE,
THEN,
IS NOT AN ACT,
BUT A HABIT.

— after Aristotle (Will Durant)

Not a stray moment of brilliance but the sum of what you do over and over.
Attributed here honestly: it's Will Durant's 1926 summary of Aristotle, not
Aristotle's own words (see SOURCES).

IT ALWAYS
SEEMS
IMPOSSIBLE
UNTIL
IT'S DONE.

— traditional

The closing note of the set: every story in *True Grit* looked impossible from inside it — right up until the person did it anyway. (Widely attributed to Nelson Mandela; the attribution is unverified, so we credit it as "traditional" — see SOURCES.)